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EFFECTS OF PERCEIVED PLACENESS ON TOURISTS' AUTHENTICITY EXPERIENCE VIA THE MEDIATING ROLE OF FLOW EXPERIENCE

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Based on the case of Gaoshanliushui *in China, our research empirically examines the mediating effect of tourists' flow experience on the relationship between perceived placeness and satisfaction as well as their perceived authenticity from the perspective of existential authenticity in the ethnic tourism context. Moreover, we present a moderated mediation model and postulate the role that tourists' cultural intelligence plays in improving satisfaction and perceived authenticity. We review the way it links perceived placeness to outcomes through the flow experience. The theoretical model and hypotheses were empirically tested using 509 questionnaires collected in July 2019. The theoretical and managerial implications are discussed.*

KEYWORDS: *flow experience; perceived placeness; satisfaction; perceived authenticity; cultural intelligence*

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HIGHLIGHTS

- Tourist flow experience mediates the relationship between perceived placeness and satisfaction, as well as perceived authenticity.
- Based on flow theory and existential experience perspective, the relationship between tourist perceived placeness and its effects through the perspective of flow experience is empirically verified.
- The moderator of cultural intelligence extends the study of perceived placeness effects on tourists' flow experience in the ethnic tourism context.

INTRODUCTION

Tourism is described as an activity to consume places (Rakić & Chambers, 2012), which encompasses not only to tourists' experience but also their perception of placeness and authenticity, especially in a heritage, cultural, or ethnic tourism setting (P. Jackson, 2004; Su, 2010). Placeness is defined as the spaces of circulation, communication, and consumption connected historically or related to an identity that are embedded in distinctive physical landscapes; it also demonstrates individuals' emotion and meaning toward a place (Augé, 2006; Colomer, 2020). Earlier studies have taken either an objective or constructive perspective to understand how tourists evaluate placeness and suggested that the more tourists' perceive traditional culture or creation of symbols, the stronger their sense of authenticity will be (e.g., Kolar & Zabkar, 2010; Rickly-Boyd, 2013). Meanwhile, others reject authenticity as a dichotomous concept (real/fake) and assert that authenticity comes from the ever-changing experiences between people and places (Brown, 2013). For instance, some scholars suggest that tourists in Lijiang (Su, 2010), Lhasa (Hu & Bai, 2015), and Nyuh-Kuning (Jeong, 2021) can enhance their satisfaction and embrace self-related authenticity more because of multisensory placeness. In addition, research has adopted a "Best Tourism Place" (BTP) perspective, emphasizing that tourists can drive themselves into a *communitas* (a state of flow-like experience) and obtain a sense of authenticity by interacting with place offerings (Lew, 2011; N. Wang, 1999). BTP emphasizes existential specialness, for example, a place with physical challenges and sensory stimulation can trigger tourists' authenticity based on existential perspective (Lew, 2011). However, current research mainly covers qualitative interpretation, there is a relative lack of empirical research focusing on both the placeness and authenticity judgement based on existential experience approach in the ethnic tourism context.

Whereas previous research has significantly improved our understanding of why place as a lived experience motivates tourists to act spontaneously and gain authentic feelings, the broader literature on place and human experience suggests that there are other factors that may lead to tourists' existential authenticity. For example, two dimensions of tourists' existential authenticity have been identified as intrapersonal (bodily feelings and self-making) and interpersonal (family ties and *communitas*; Buchmann et al., 2010; Rickly-Boyd, 2013; N. Wang,

1999). Thus, just as a self-making experience is energized from goal fulfilment, studies on flow experience indicate that people can put themselves on display, seek suitable challenges and compensate for the boredom and lack of authenticity felt in usual life (Macbeth, 1988; Vester, 1987; N. Wang, 1999). According to flow theory (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990), flow experience is defined as individuals' ecstasy experience when their higher skills are matched with stronger challenges. It can help tourists gain authentic and positive outcomes (da Silva deMatos et al., 2021; Tiberghien et al., 2020). However, few scholars, have empirically verified the relationship between placeness perception and existential authenticity from a process of flow experience of self-making, and even fewer have revealed its relevance in cultural or ethnic tourism context. Although predominant explanations for how external challenges drive tourists' self-making and authenticity experience, flow theory suggests that personal flow state is also driven by individuals' skills. There are only a few studies on how tourists adjust their skills and adaptability to enhance their authenticity evaluation in a cross-cultural experience.

Ethnic tourism is where the "quaint" customs of indigenous or exotic culture are considered attractions (Smith, 1977). As compared with locals, tourists' sense of place cannot be entrenched in their minds for a historical process. Hence, they may gain more existential authenticity from on-site experiences with placeness perception (Hu & Bai, 2015). Also, some research has explicated that cultural or heritage tourists are more willing to find moments of spiritual awareness and experiential feelings compared with historic tourists (Yi et al., 2017). To address the aforementioned research gaps, we integrate the epistemological understandings of existential authenticity with the literature and develop a flow theory perspective to explain how and why perceived placeness affects tourists' authenticity experience and satisfaction. Our study aims to (1) develop a conceptual model to reveal the influence of tourists' perceived placeness (PP) on satisfaction and perceived authenticity (PA) through the mediator of flow experience (FE), (2) explore the moderating effect of tourists' cross-cultural skills on the relationship between FE and satisfaction and PA by using a cultural intelligence measurement, and (3) mentor ethnic tourism managers to link local distinctiveness with tourists' flow state and authenticity experience in practical aspects.

LITERATURE REVIEW AND HYPOTHESES

Place and Placeness

A "place" emphasizes the human–place relationship between a physical setting and one's personal experiences toward the environment (Tuan, 1977). In place-related concepts, place attachment is usually used and underlines a psychological process that people develop toward the place (Hidalgo & Hernández, 2001; Scannell & Gifford, 2010). It can reflect people's beliefs, emotions, cognitions, and behavior domains for a specific place, including two dimensions: place dependence and place identity (Woosnam et al., 2018). While the former

emphasizes the significance of a place in meeting an individual's needs and desired activities, the latter highlights an individual's personal affective bonds (values, feelings, and beliefs) about the world (Stokols & Shumaker, 1981; Tsai, 2012; Williams et al., 1992).

Placeness is defined as connecting people's place attachment and reflects the congruence between the individual's perception of local distinctiveness, self-concept, and a place's meaning and symbolism (Relph, 1976; Truong et al., 2018; Tsai, 2012; Wigley, 2018). Augé (2006) stated that, compared with "non-places, "placeness" is relevant to the rooted culture, memories, and identities attached to individuals. Placeness as functional distinctiveness is embedded in the physical landscapes and closely connected with tourists' perception that the representation possesses uniqueness (Prayag & Ryan, 2012). Meanwhile, placeness can also be reflected through the individual's emotions or beliefs toward a unique place (Truong et al., 2018). For locals, their sense of place has long been rooted in minds, emotions and memories (S. Wang & Xu, 2015); therefore, it is harder for them to be aware of local uniqueness. Conversely, the local distinctiveness will be imagined, constructed, and perceived easier by tourists because they distinguish between "self" and "others" (Hu & Bai, 2015). When tourists feel the destination is so unique in its origin or in their projection that no equivalent exists elsewhere, they perceive placeness first and then gradually transform into place identity, thus obtaining a feeling of authenticity based on the placeness assessment (e.g., Hu & Bai, 2015; Ram et al., 2016; Truong et al., 2018). Therefore, it is fundamentally important to explore the effects of tourists' PP.

Place and Existential Authenticity

In contrast to the epistemology of objective and constructive authenticity, the existential authenticity emphasizes the subjective experience and a sense of self or a state of being (true to oneself; Brown, 2013; N. Wang, 1999). To pursue a sense of freedom through the pilgrimage, tourists' existential authenticity even exceeds their objective authenticity experienced in cultural sites (Andriotis, 2011; Bryce et al., 2015). A place, as experienced by others, is historically organic and offers the potential process of self-discovery (H. Kim & Jamal, 2007; Yi et al., 2017). During place activities, tourists may experience self-awareness and develop an alignment of personal authenticity and behavior by self-judgments (Fu, 2019; N. Wang, 1999). Similarly, the BTP that contains diverse local culture, activities, and physical challenges can strengthen tourists' existential authenticity via sensory stimulation (Lew, 2011). Hence, tourists' experiences of local uniqueness are an existential element of the authenticity that exists in original places or multiple copies (Kolar & Zabkar, 2010).

Flow Experience

FE is defined as a positive psychological state, where people are involved in enjoyable activities to which nothing else compares (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990).

Flow occurs when activities are associated with high levels of an individual's skills and challenges (S. A. Jackson, 1996). In these challenging activities, people with skills are more easily aroused by clear goals and involved in deep activities. They feel in control of their environment, lose their self-consciousness (shifting their awareness on the activity), and perceive temporal dissociation in stimulating activities (Hsu & Lu, 2004). The theoretical framework of flow theory posits that the embodied participation processes help individuals enhance cognitive stimulation, such as focus (or attention), instant feedback, combination of action and awareness, time distortion, and autotelic experience (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990). Meanwhile, FE can cause positive consequences, such as pleasure, enjoyment, satisfaction, or well-being (Nakamura & Csikszentmihalyi, 2009; Tse et al., 2020).

Flow state usually occurs when individuals spontaneously achieve intrinsic hedonic emotions, enjoyable feelings, and arousal cognitions about their inner self in specific activities (e.g., outdoor recreation; da Silva deMatos et al., 2021; M. Kim & Thapa, 2018; Wu & Liang, 2011). The activity-based designs with scenarios allow users to have a feeling of interest, rejuvenation or being present, and it drives their intrapersonal authenticity (Rickly-Boyd, 2013; N. Wang, 1999). For the ethnic tourism case of *Gaoshanliushui*, tourists' experiential value is not just the pursuit of local culture. When tourists are immersed in local activities that evoke their intrinsic interest and curiosity, they are more prone to experience the flow in human-place interaction and skill-challenge balance (Hsu & Lu, 2004; Tse et al., 2020). Thus, it is appropriate to apply the flow theory perspective in the context of ethnic tourism.

Perceived Placeness and Flow Experience

Previous studies have determined that place characteristics (e.g., design, setting, or landscape) stimulate individuals' positive impact on their experience and enhance their behavioral intentions (Bryce et al., 2015; Kolar & Zabkar, 2010; Richards, 2020). When tourists encounter local distinctiveness, they regulate their experience consciously or unconsciously to maintain a sense of self. Thus, tourists express deeper understanding of the physical or cultural environment (Truong et al., 2018; S. Wang & Xu, 2015).

In the ethnic tourism setting, designers create a local distinctiveness to create stimulating and challenging experiences for tourists. It separates tourists from their daily lives and establishes a *communitas/zone* (flow-like state), and they can express their true selves, gain emotional energy, and pursue goals (Borovay et al., 2019; H. Kim & Jamal, 2007; Rickly-Boyd, 2013; N. Wang, 1999). Lew (2011) stated that place that combines outstanding local cultures and landscapes, sensory stimulation, experiential diversity, or appropriate challenges can help tourists immerse themselves in deep experiences. Richer experiential heritage environments trigger tourists into a state of *pilgrimage*, and they achieve a sense of freedom (Andriotis, 2011; Fu, 2019). Gao et al. (2017) claimed that the unique

and challenging place-related activities can drive tourists' FE. Thus, the following hypothesis is formulated:

Hypothesis 1: PP has a positive effect on FE.

Flow Experience, Satisfaction, and Perceived Authenticity

Satisfaction is generally defined as an outcome from an actual experience as compared with the expected experience (D. Kim & Ko, 2019). Usually, satisfaction measures an individual's extent of fulfillment and their emotional response to a related experience (Landon et al., 2020). Satisfaction can also be used as a subjective assessment to reflect the experiential quality (Cetin, 2020). Most tourism scholars understand satisfaction as a behavioral reaction to the FE (da Silva deMatos et al., 2021). For instance, Wu and Liang (2011) stated that the challenge of white-water rafting helps tourists achieve a flow state, leading to satisfaction. Cater et al. (2021) found that tourists' FE has a positive impact on satisfaction in scuba diving. Therefore, we propose:

Hypothesis 2: FE has a positive effect on satisfaction.

Tourists' FE of intrapersonal authenticity involves self-identity and self-making. It helps them escape the daily routine through an existential "sensual transcendence" (N. Wang, 1999). When tourists participate in some embodied activities, such as a local celebration or wine-drinking ceremony, they can easily obtain an authentic perception (Rickly-Boyd, 2013; Su, 2010). Some studies have verified the relationship between the flow-like experience and authenticity from the existential perspective. Gilmore and Pine (2007) argued that PA is an important outcome of a memorable or flow-like experience. Zatori et al. (2018) revealed that an emotional, involved, and flow-like experience positively affects tourists' authentic experience. Hence, the following hypothesis is formulated:

Hypothesis 3: FE has a positive effect on PA.

The Mediating Role of the Flow Experience

The FE as an interpretation mechanism of psychological states mediates the environment (or place) and the outcomes of the individual's experience (da Silva deMatos et al., 2021; M. Kim & Thapa, 2018). Research confirmed that tourists' evaluations of the place positively influence their FE, thus leading to positive behaviors, such as satisfaction (Cater et al., 2021; M. Kim & Thapa, 2018). Previous research clarified that both real physical places and the broader nexus of the lived experience and sociospatial relations lead us toward a perspective on existential authenticity (Uriely & Belhassen, 2005). For example, Buchmann et al. (2010) showed that tourists' existential authenticity is framed

by their lived experience with fellow fans at the locations of filming, the significance of the various landscapes promotes tourists' flow-like experience, and PA. In addition, combining Hypotheses 1 to 3, we propose the following:

Hypothesis 4: FE mediates the positive relationship between PP and satisfaction.
Hypothesis 5: FE mediates the positive relationship between PP and PA.

The Moderating Role of Cultural Intelligence

The above hypotheses propose that PP is most likely to strengthen tourists' satisfaction and PA when challenging scenes activate their FE. We recognize that the influence of challenging places on satisfaction or PA cannot be consistently applied across all tourists. A central tenant of flow theory is that individuals enhance cognitive stimulation through their strong skills in an enormously challenging environment. This individual heterogeneity is captured by cultural intelligence (CQ), an ego "skill" that refers to an individual's ability to understand a challenging (or unfamiliar) culture, shape an adequate cognition, and behave appropriately in cross-culture situations (Ang et al., 2007). Previous research explains how CQ interferes with the individuals' positive outcomes in four dimensions: metacognitive, cognitive, motivational, and behavioral CQ (e.g., Ang et al., 2007; Earley & Ang, 2003).

First, metacognitive CQ refers to conscious cultural awareness that regulates personal learning capabilities and promotes one's thinking about situations in cross-cultural interactions (Thomas et al., 2008). It deliberately monitors an individual's cognitive and affective states and adjusts these states to suit the goals (Thomas et al., 2015). This aspect leads us to consider that CQ can regulate tourists' challenges of local distinctiveness, reducing anxiety or burnout caused by unfamiliar cultures, increasing the level of thinking and deeper cognitions, and enhancing the effects of tourists' task performance. Second, cognitive CQ is composed of general knowledge (i.e., norms, conventions, or practices) and content-specific knowledge about different cultures (e.g., Ang et al., 2007; Min et al., 2021; Thomas et al., 2015). When tourists are more likely to make intercultural judgment because of their cultural knowledge, the intercultural adaptation interacts with the tourists' level of FE, such that the level of flow state is enhanced as attention is focused on the personal possession of cognitive skills with regard to their understanding of how place activities and cultures relate to the landscapes and experiential diversity. Third, motivational CQ occurs when individuals' interest triggers physical participation that is characterized by intercultural distinctiveness interaction with different people (Min et al., 2021). This perspective demonstrates that tourists with higher motivation and interest are more likely to participate in challenges shaped by intercultural placeness, thus reducing boredom and increasing the effects of flow state on experience performance (i.e., satisfaction and PA). Finally, behavioral CQ is seen as the ability for individuals to regulate their verbal and nonverbal actions to cater to the goals of

a distinctive cultural setting (Van Dyne et al., 2008). When relevant behavioral flexibility suits the needs of an intercultural context, personal cultural skill is demonstrated as cognitive intelligence (Thomas et al., 2015). Thus, tourists may feel anxiety when they encounter the challenges of local distinctiveness, but adjust and adapt to any cross-cultural context, individuals' anxiety will be lower. They can facilitate flow state and perform incremental validity over cognitive intelligence, thus promoting expected satisfaction and authenticity. In other words, as an individual's skill, the combination of four CQ dimensions leads us to explain how tourists enhance the effectiveness of PA and satisfaction during the FE.

According to the intelligence theory (Sternberg, 2003), intelligence (such as CQ) can automatically package and recombine new information and transform information into a set of psychological resources that are easier to use and manage (Presbitero, 2020). This psychological mechanism of CQ actively triggers tourists' engagement and helps them modify the behaviors for local distinctiveness. For metacognitive and cognitive CQ, tourists who perceive placeness from cross-cultural context would obtain distinctive preference and expectation and know more about instant feedback to combinate awareness and intercultural action. With the intervention of motivational and behavioral CQ, tourists who are more interested in enjoying interaction with local challenges would feel time distortion and adjust verbal or nonverbal behavior to autotelic experience. Therefore, the core logic is that CQ can help an individual's cognitive stimulation be continuously transformed into greater utility in the context of placeness perception (Sharma & Hussain, 2017).

In addition, CQ is a notion of culture that is free of an etic construct, is not culture-bound to emic constructs, and can be defined as a stable personality trait (Earley & Ang, 2003), it is more appropriate as a moderator. Empirical research demonstrates these viewpoints, for instance, Frías-Jamilena et al. (2018) revealed that a higher CQ helps tourists communicate with others in cross-cultural interactions, thus leading to satisfaction. Bahrami and Narafshan (2018) found that CQ has a positive moderating effect on the link between interpersonal experience and multiauthenticity. In sum, a core factor that is consistent across theoretical explanation of CQ is the linkage of a skill or behavioral component (Thomas et al., 2015). Hence, we predict that a higher CQ can promote tourists to convert FE into positive experiential behaviors. Also, with the above hypotheses on mediation (Figure 1), we propose the following:

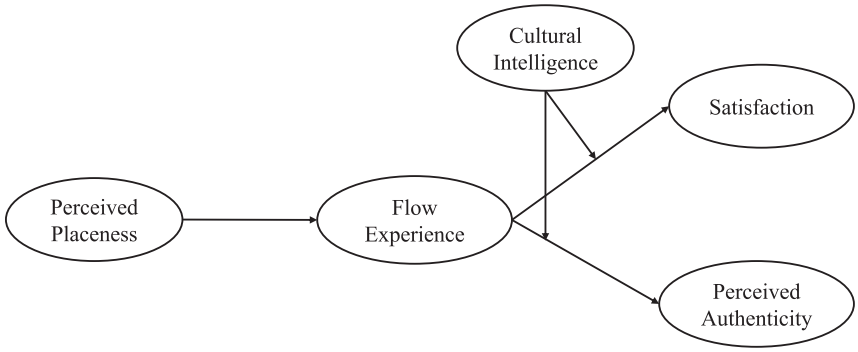
Hypothesis 6: CQ moderates the indirect effect of FE on satisfaction.

Hypothesis 7: CQ moderates the indirect effect of FE on PA.

Hypothesis 8: CQ moderates the indirect effect of PP on satisfaction via FE, such that the indirect effects would be stronger when the CQ is higher.

Hypothesis 9: CQ moderates the indirect effect of PP on PA via FE, such that the indirect effects would be stronger when the CQ is higher.

Figure 1
The Conceptual Model of This Study



RESEARCH METHODS

Measurements

The measures are constructed based on the relevant studies. As these measurement scales are in English, our study translates all the measurements into Chinese. It is specific to the special cultural context of this study, to ensure the equivalency of the meaning (Whetten, 2009). All items are measured on a 5-point Likert-type scale, with *strongly disagree* (1) and *strongly agree* (5) as the anchors.

First, PP is measured by combining the distinctiveness perception, the place dependence, and the affective attachment existing scales. It consists of nine items (Truong et al., 2018; Tsai, 2012; S. Wang & Xu, 2015). Second, we adopt a three-item scale to measure tourists' FE (D. Kim & Ko, 2019; M. Kim & Thapa, 2018). Third, the five-item scale employed to measure tourists' satisfaction is adapted from M. Kim and Thapa (2018) and Kang et al. (2018). Fourth, the five-item scale of PA (existential construct) is measured following Zatori et al. (2018) and Kolar and Zabkar (2010). Moreover, the CQ is measured with a total of eight items to present tourists' adaptability (Earley & Ang, 2003; Thomas, 2006). Finally, tourists' demographic information are used as the control variables based on the related research (S. Wang & Chen, 2015).

Data Collection

This study is conducted in Xijiang Miao Village (Guizhou, China). We selected the *Gaoshanliushui* toast ceremony as an example, and this case study involves both the placeness of the Miao rice wine culture and tourists' in situ experience. During the toast ceremony, tourists can easily enter the flow state by continuously engaging in challenging activities like rice wine drinking and

place-based activities. These include Miao *Lusheng* dancing, and *Weifan*, or embodied interactions. Hence, *Gaoshanliushui* offers a typical case that reflects our research aim.

Data collection is divided into two phases. The precollection stage was from July 3 to 6, 2019, and the formal collection was from July 9 to 16, 2019. In phase one, 200 questionnaires were distributed and 195 were collected, for an available rate of 97.50%. The authors tested the validity of the precollection results, eliminated items with low reliability, and modified the possible ambiguity of the questionnaire language. The formal questionnaire was adopted in phase two. Twelve investigators were divided into four groups to conduct a convenience sampling technique. An on-site survey in Miao restaurants was conducted. To ensure an effective survey for our research, the respondents needed to be nonlocal tourists. They were determined at the beginning of the investigation. To enhance the quality of the data collection; the investigators selected tourists to complete the questionnaires who were sober after completing the challenging experiences. Finally, 550 questionnaires were distributed, 525 were collected and 509 were valid, for an available rate of 92.55%. Statistics show that 64.80% are men, the percentage of tourists from Miao is 17.10%, 82.90% are aged 19 to 45 years, 69.70% hold a college degree or above, and 59.80% are businessmen, service employees, teachers, students, or serve in public institutions.

FINDINGS

Data Normality and Common Method Bias Analysis

Data normality was confirmed with skewness (from −1.383 to −0.444) and kurtosis (from −0.635 to 2.974) the range of items. This supported good normal distribution according to Kline (2011). The single-factor test is conducted to statistically evaluate the underlying seriousness of the common method bias. This followed the recommendation of Anderson and Gerbing (1988). Five factors with eigenvalues greater than one emerged. The first factor and the five factors together account for 18.51% and 69.17% of the total variance, respectively. Since the first factor accounts for a small proportion (far less than 50%) and several factors emerged, the common method bias does not appear to be a serious problem (Podsakoff et al., 2003).

Confirmatory Factor Analysis

We conduct a series of confirmatory factor analyses to examine the distinctiveness of our study's constructs with maximum-likelihood estimation in M*plus*7.0 before testing the hypotheses (Muthén & Muthén, 2012). The results demonstrated that the five-factor measurement model yielded a good model fit for the data ($\chi^2 = 1163.54$, degrees of freedom [*df*] = 395, comparative fit index [CFI] = 0.93, Tucker–Lewis index [TLI] = 0.92, root mean square error of approximation [RMSEA] = 0.06, standardized root mean square residual

[SRMR] = 0.05; see online Supplement Table 1). All factor loadings were significant. The five-factor model improved significantly over the alternative models, thus demonstrating good convergent validity (Bentler & Bonett, 1980).

Descriptive Statistics

All items are reported in Table 1. The factor loadings of these constructs were statistically significant (0.69 to 0.93 level; Barclay et al., 1995). The constructs have adequate and satisfactory convergent validity, as all the constructs' average variance extracted (AVE) values were higher than the threshold of 0.50 (Hair et al., 2014). The Cronbach's alpha values of these constructs, and the composite reliability, were higher than .89. This illustrates a strong internal consistency based on all measures. The means, standard deviations, reliabilities, zero-order Pearson correlations, and the square root of the AVEs are reported in Table 2. As our analysis revealed, PP is positively correlated with the FE ($r = .56, p < .01$), satisfaction ($r = .44, p < .01$), and PA ($r = .30, p < .01$). The FE is positively correlated with satisfaction ($r = .36, p < .01$) and PA ($r = .27, p < .01$). Moreover, the satisfaction and PA are positively intercorrelated ($r = .58, p < .01$), thus providing preliminary support for our hypotheses.

Hypotheses Testing

We examined the regression coefficients with structural equation modeling and used M*plus* 7.0 for the bias-corrected bootstrap method. The results of standardized path regression coefficient showed that PP was positively related to the FE ($\beta = .61$, standard error [*SE*] = 0.04, $p < .001$). It also showed that the FE was positively related to satisfaction ($\beta = .15$, $SE = .07$, $p < .05$), and PA ($\beta = .16$, $SE = 0.07$, $p < .05$; see online Supplement Figure 1). The 95% bias-corrected confidence interval (CI) of effects did not include zero. Thus, Hypotheses 1, 2, and 3 were supported.

For the mediation analysis, the indirect effect and a 95% bias-corrected CI were estimated by a bootstrapping analysis with 5,000 iterations (MacKinnon et al., 2007). The results revealed that the mediating effects of the FE were statistically significant (see online Supplement Table 2). For satisfaction, the specific indirect effect is 0.09 (boot 95% CI [0.012, 0.177]), and the direct effect is 0.38 (boot 95% CI [0.251, 0.489]). For PA, the indirect effect is 0.10 (boot 95% CI [0.007, 0.177]), and the direct effect is 0.23 (boot 95% CI [0.097, 0.357]). This indicated that Hypotheses 4 and 5 were both supported.

We tested the second-stage moderated-mediation model using PROCESS macro, which is a versatile modeling tool freely available for SPSS (Hayes, 2012). Specifically, we selected the Model 14 analysis in PROCESS and utilized the bias-corrected bootstrapping technique with 5,000 samples to construct bias-corrected CI for testing indirect effects (Mackinnon et al., 2004). Data analysis

Table 1
Reliability and Validity of the Constructs

Constructs	Items	Standard Factor Loading	α	CR	AVE
Perceived placeness	I like the *Gaoshanliushui* of Xijiang, which is hard to experience in other places.	0.78	.92	.92	0.55
	Compared with other wine-drinking and toasting ceremonies, *Gaoshanliushui* is distinctive.	0.72			
	For me, the *Gaoshanliushui* of Xijiang satisfies the needs of an experience.	0.79			
	The atmosphere where local people like to drink wine made me blend into this place.	0.77			
	Gaoshanliushui is an important part of my tourism experience here.	0.72			
	I strongly identify with the toasting ceremony of *Gaoshanliushui*.	0.69			
	I feel like this place is a part of me when I experience the atmosphere of *Gaoshanliushui*.	0.69			
	Gaoshanliushui is very special to me, and the experience is very meaningful.	0.71			
	I miss this toasting ceremony very much.	0.83			
Flow experience	I think I can experience the flow during the wine-drinking and toasting ceremony.	0.93	.93	.93	0.81
	I can quickly reach a state of flow experience.	0.92			
	Most of the time, when I experience the ceremony, I can experience the flow.	0.85			
Satisfaction	I am satisfied with the overall *Gaoshanliushui* experience.	0.76	.90	.90	0.64
	It is a really nice experience; other tourism productions of wine-drinking cannot be compared.	0.73			
	I recommend that others experience the *Gaoshanliushui* in Xijiang.	0.88			
	I will come here again to experience *Gaoshanliushui*.	0.81			
	Satisfaction with this experience exceeded my expectations.	0.80			

(continued)

Table 1 (continued)

Constructs	Items	Standard Factor Loading	α	CR	AVE
Perceived authenticity	I can feel the original ethnic customs by the *Gaoshanliushui*.	0.80	.89	.89	0.62
	It has a strong local life and cultural atmosphere.	0.81			
	Gaoshanliushui reflects simple local customs.	0.80			
	I can experience real, local culture when I am immersed in this toasting ceremony and drinking.	0.76			
	I acquired knowledge and insight about myself during the *Gaoshanliushui*, as it is a real feeling.	0.75			
Cultural intelligence	I began to change my common cultural knowledge about drinking when I interacted with Miao people.	0.75	.93	.93	0.63
	I began to take the initiative to pay attention to their cultural characteristics when I interacted with Miao people.	0.78			
	I understand the nonverbal behavior expression rules of the Miao people.	0.74			
	I like interacting with the local people.	0.80			
	I can communicate with the Miao people to understand them and their local culture.	0.82			
	I will choose different ways of dealing with conflict when I need to communicate with the Miao people.	0.82			
	I am willing to change my nonverbal behavior when interacting with Miao people.	0.84			
	I am willing to learn the language of the Miao people when communicating with them.	0.81			

Note: CR = composite reliability; AVE = average variance extracted.

Table 2
Correlations, Means, and Standard Deviations of All the Variables in the Study

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1. Gender	—							
2. Education	−0.07	—						
3. Profession	0.13**	0.05	—					
4. Perceived placeness	0.03	−0.05	−0.05	**0.74**				
5. Flow experience	0.06	−0.01	0.01	0.56**	**0.90**			
6. Cultural intelligence	0.12**	−0.04	0.06	0.52**	0.42**	**0.79**		
7. Satisfaction	0.08	−0.06	0.01	0.44**	0.36**	0.49**	**0.80**	
8. Perceived authenticity	0.02	−0.03	−0.02	0.30**	0.27**	0.33**	0.58**	**0.79**
Mean	1.35	4.09	7.70	4.14	4.24	4.00	4.33	4.28
Standard deviation	0.48	1.26	3.42	0.65	0.77	0.77	0.63	0.60

Note: $N = 509$. Diagonal data [in boldface] are the square roots of the average variance extracted.
*$p < .05$. **$p < .01$.

results (see online Supplement Table 3) show that the interaction term was positively related to satisfaction ($\beta = .19$, $SE = 0.04$, $p < .001$) and PA ($\beta = .15$, $SE = 0.04$, $p < .001$). For satisfaction, the results revealed that the FE was significantly positively related to satisfaction when CQ is high ($\beta = .33$, $SE = .06$, $p < .001$). This relationship was not significant when the CQ was low ($\beta = .08$, *ns*). This supported Hypothesis 6. For PA, the results revealed the FE was significantly positively related to PA when CQ was high ($\beta = .27$, $SE = 0.06$, $p < .001$). The relationship was not significant when the CQ was low ($\beta = .06$, *ns*), thus supporting Hypothesis 7.

Finally, we tested the moderated mediation effects. For satisfaction, the indirect relationship was significant between PP and satisfaction when the CQ was high (in other words, conditional indirect effect = 0.18, boot 95% CI [0.111, 0.259]). This was in comparison with when it was low (in other words, conditional indirect effect = −0.01, boot 95% CI = [−0.093, 0.065], *ns*). Furthermore, the FE had a significant indirect effect on the relationship between PP and PA when the CQ was high (in other words, conditional indirect effect = 0.16, boot 95% CI [0.083, 0.241]). This was in comparison with when it was low (in other words, conditional indirect effect = 0.01, boot 95% CI [−0.076, 0.069], *ns*). Moreover, the index of the moderated mediation was consulted as a more definitive test (Hayes, 2012). The index of the moderated mediation was statistically significant for satisfaction (index = 0.12, boot 95% CI = [0.054, 0.190]), and PA (index = 0.102, boot 95% CI = [0.038, 0.167]), respectively. Therefore, Hypotheses 8 and 9 were supported. Furthermore, we followed Spiller et al. (2013) and adopted the floodlight analyses of Johnson–Neyman technique to determine the significant regions. As shown in Figure 2, low-CQ tourists had a higher level of satisfaction than high-CQ individuals when the level of FE was less than 1.67; however, when the level of FE was greater than 3.56, high-CQ

Figure 2
Cultural Intelligence (CQ) × Flow Experience Interaction on Satisfaction

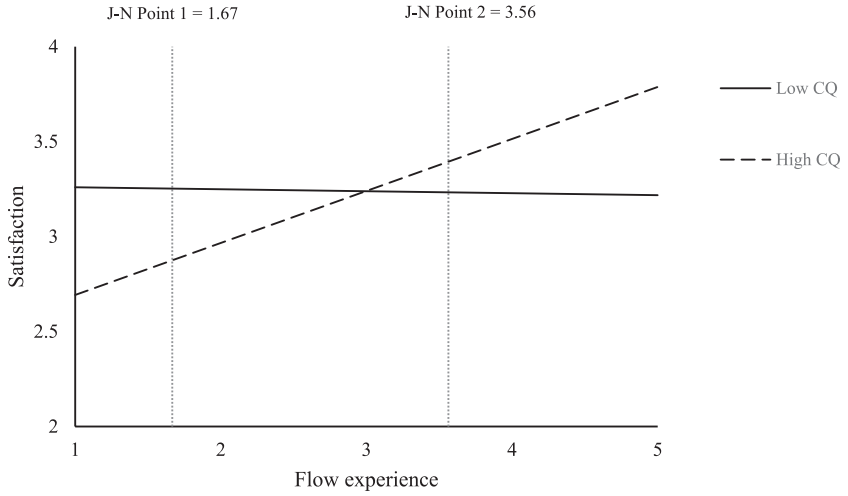
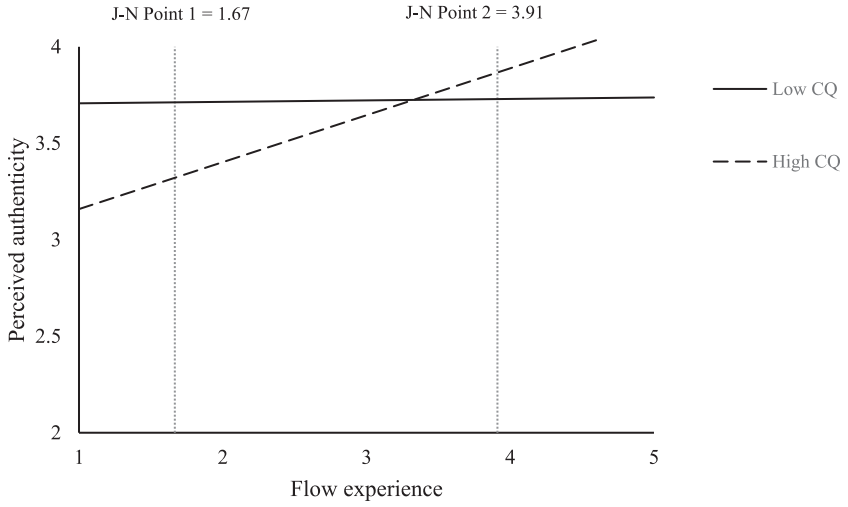


Figure 3
Cultural Intelligence (CQ) × Flow Experience Interaction on Perceived Authenticity



tourists exhibited a higher level of satisfaction than low-CQ individuals. Similarly, Figure 3 showed that low-CQ tourists had a higher level of PA than high-CQ individuals when the level of FE was less than 1.67, and high-CQ tourists showed a higher level of PA than low-CQ individuals when the level of FE was greater than 3.91.

CONCLUSION AND DISCUSSION

Theoretical Implications

First, our study contributes to ethnic tourism literature using a new mechanism and existential perspective through which placeness is likely to influence tourists' satisfaction and PA. Previous research has explored the links between placeness and tourists' experience behaviors based on objective or constructive perspective, relevant theories include place-making, power relationships, and social space production (e.g., Amoamo, 2013; Lew, 2017; Nost, 2013). Unlike previous studies, we argue that authentic experience can stem from tourists' pursuit of challenge and self-making (or a state of being). We suggest that such placeness with activities or multisensory interactions may trigger tourists to seek suitable challenges and compensate for the boredom and lack of authenticity felt in daily life. It improves tourists' satisfaction and PA rather than objective culture and so-called contextual marketing. In our case, we further consider that the placeness of ethnic tourism was shaped by its local culture and a set of interactions between the objects and bodies, affects, and perceptions. Tourists can achieve a moment of spiritual awareness and feel a connection with traditional ethnic culture. We push the qualitative research to empirical verification that reveals the linkage between place matters and an individual's existential experience (Rickly-Boyd, 2013). Our research offers a construct for a place-based analysis of existential authenticity perspective.

Second, our study takes a FE approach to develop an in-depth understanding of how and why PP leads to satisfaction and PA. By examining the mediating mechanism of FE, we held that tourists feel authentic and satisfied not due to "real and historical" authenticity or staged performance. This is because distinctive activities improve cognitive stimulation and intrapersonal authenticity of self-making (da Silva deMatos et al., 2021; Fu, 2019; Lew, 2011). Different from other explanatory mechanisms, such as cultural pilgrimage (Andriotis, 2011), engagement (Bryce et al., 2015), or involvement (Zatori et al., 2018), we argue tourists can also perceive authenticity in ethnic tourism by participating in the form of challenging themselves and activating their flow state. According to qualitative research, FE is thought to be an exhibition of self-making that tourist break the usual structures and achieve intrapersonal authenticity (H. Kim & Jamal, 2007; Vester, 1987; N. Wang, 1999), but it lacks sufficient empirical validation. Our findings support the conclusion of relevant scholars that tourists' FE is a psychological capacity which connects placeness with existential authenticity. It provides a new understanding of mediation mechanism of cognitive stimulating that links placeness and personal affective bonds (e.g., enjoyment and immersion; Rickly-Boyd, 2013; N. Wang, 1999). For ethnic tourism, the FE enhances tourists' identification with placeness and evokes subsequent authentic outcomes.

Third, our study explores tourists' CQ as a moderator. CQ is being explored as a fresh emerging intelligence, it is more focused in the contexts

of employees' organizational behavior, international business, education, or learning (e.g., Ang et al., 2007; Min et al., 2021; Presbitero, 2020; Sharma & Hussain, 2017). We expand the boundary of research contexts via presenting CQ as an effective individual skill for tourists who seek authenticity in the ethnic tourism experience. Combined with flow theory, our study demonstrates that CQ is another feasible skill that helps tourists interact with challenges of local distinctiveness, reduces psychological stress, and increases the level of deeper cognitions, thus enhancing the effects of FE. Our findings gradually shift the study of CQ from organization situations to tourists' experience, utilizing various tourism settings. Furthermore, our study combines four dimensions of CQ to explore tourists' cognition and behavior that CQ is constituted by a set of cross-cultural skills that can enable people to interact with challenges of local distinctiveness. Cultural metacognition monitors tourists' thinking and learning capabilities, resulting in higher levels of flow state, which is critical when they get involved in a distinctive place, such as in *Gaoshanliushui*. Cognitive CQ as cultural knowledge enriches tourists' cognitive skills, which helps them initiate their self-efficacy to recognize the relationship between distinctiveness and the self (Thomas et al., 2015), thus improving their effects of FE. Motivational and behavioral CQ indicate that tourists with higher motivation are more likely to improve their levels of self-making, reduce boredom, behave suitably, and facilitate the effects of FE on satisfaction and PA. In sum, the intervention mechanism of CQ drives the transformation of an individual's cognitive system from stimulation, maintenance to behavior (Sharma & Hussain, 2017). The effects of moderating of CQ of four dimensions demonstrate that the positive regulation from cognition (FE) to behaviors (satisfaction and PA) is a comprehensive transformation process.

Practical Implications

First, the findings suggested that tourists' PP can trigger satisfaction and PA with regard to ethnic tourism. Hence, ethnic tourism organizers should design unique local positioning strategies based on respect for the traditional culture. It should also construct core placeness to expand the maximum implementation level of tourists' place identity. In the case of *Gaoshanliushui*, we recommend tourism managers integrate the cultural and tourism resources (e.g., food, servicescape) into one or two of the most unique attributes for an effective place identification (Richards, 2020).

Second, our study provided practical recommendations for an ethnic tourism place-making intervention from the perspective of the FE. The findings of this research suggested that ethnic tourism should innovate by using local distinctiveness to create an activity-based or challenging servicescape that facilitates the interaction between the historical culture and an experiential place (Fu, 2019; Jeong, 2021; H. Kim & Jamal, 2007). It would help visitors escape the simulated scene of homogeneity.

Third, our results advocated for CQ interventions in the cross-cultural setting, by confirming the facilitating role of tourists' CQ in enhancing the positive effects of the FE on satisfaction and PA. The destination may benefit from more proactive intervention strategies, such as creating an environment surrounded by a unique cultural society of folk customs, religious beliefs, ceremonies, music, or food to promote deeper tourism experiences (Truong et al., 2018). Our research can provide some ideas for managers to balance tourism development and cultural place protection. It is necessary to consider both sides that highlight the local distinctiveness and create a flow-like experiential place. This process of placeness construction can activate tourists' ecstasy experience and authenticity cognition. It prevents visitors from evaluating the cultural authenticity only by gazing at an objective culture (Truong et al., 2018). The case of *Gaoshanliushui* may be a better way to coordinate the encounter between a place and the tourism industry.

Limitations and Future Research Directions

Our study faced some limitations that point to future research directions. First, although we evaluated the potential seriousness of a common method bias statistically, it did not appear to be a serious problem for our subsequent analyses. Our results may still be affected by the common method bias due to the lack of time-lagged data resources (Podsakoff et al., 2003). In future studies, the data can be collected in three waves to reduce the common method bias. Second, we focused on verifying the influence of PP on outcomes via the FE. Compared with other place matters, the PP plays an important role in explaining how tourists evaluate the local distinctiveness in the short term. However, our study design may be incomplete; therefore, future studies may focus on other place-related variables to achieve a more comprehensive understanding.

Third, the flow state was seen as a sign of individuals' experiential interaction. It was reasonable for our study to focus on tourists' authenticity perception based on the existential authenticity analysis perspective. However, other possible authenticity behavioral reactions are worthy of further exploration. As a result, we know little about how the flow state affects tourists' perception of authenticity in a more comprehensive way. Empirical research can be conducted in the future. Finally, our research explored the setting of Chinese domestic tourists' experiences. Given cultural differences, we are unsure if the findings can be generalized to other ethnic tourism destinations. Future investigations may therefore replicate our research in a broader context by adopting multiple methods. Moreover, our research only explored tourists' CQ as a moderator. Future studies may further investigate additional boundary conditions, linked to both place-related and personal factors in the cross-cultural experience.

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SUPPLEMENTAL MATERIAL

Supplemental material for this article is available online.

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